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Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

DUBAI FOUNTAIN RETURNS IN DAZZLING COMEBACK

■ After five months of renovations, the Dubai Fountain — with its music, lights and stunning displays — returned yesterday, drawing crowds from across the UAE and beyond to witness its triumphant comeback. Long a visual marvel, the fountain now boasts a brand-new floor that gleams from above, with glowing blue tiles adding a fresh dimension to the spectacle. **SEE ALSO PAGE 2**

Qatar pushes Gaza peace bid

Trump plan ‘offers
scope if withdrawal,
governance clarified’

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

Qatar’s Prime Minister Shaikh Mohammad Bin Abdulrahman Al Thani yesterday urged all sides to seize the “momentum” to end the Gaza war, saying the US ceasefire proposal unveiled by President Donald Trump meets mediators’ key goals of halting bloodshed and displacement. Speaking to Al Jazeera, he

acknowledged “practical and implementation challenges,” but stressed the plan opens opportunities if clarified on issues like Israel’s withdrawal and a future Palestinian administration.

Hamas remains divided

The proposal, already backed by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, has been passed to Hamas’s negotiators in Doha.

A Palestinian source told AFP the group wants amendments to clauses on disarmament and expulsion of cadres, while demanding international guarantees for a full Israeli

withdrawal and protection from assassinations.

Hamas leaders remain divided, with some pushing unconditional approval to secure a ceasefire and others insisting on conditional acceptance.

Meanwhile, Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz ordered Palestinians to leave Gaza City, warning those who remain would be treated as militants. Local hospitals reported at least 16 Palestinians killed yesterday amid heavy bombardment.

Around 400,000 Palestinians have fled famine-stricken Gaza City since Israel launched a major offensive.

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Abu Dhabi to get light rail and urban loop

Urban Loop will begin pilot operations within six months

ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

Abu Dhabi Transport announced at Global Rail 2025 the launch of two landmark projects that reflect the emirate’s vision for an integrated, sustainable, and modern transport network — the Urban Loop personal rapid transit system and the Abu Dhabi Light Rail project.

The Urban Loop, a self-driving rapid transit system, will begin pilot operations within six months at two locations on Al Reem Island.

Designed to be environmentally friendly and energy-efficient, the system supports Abu Dhabi’s climate neutrality strategy. Operating 24/7, it will integrate with buses and smart mobility services. Its units feature advanced cooling systems and dust protection, making it a showcase of the

PHASE ONE



Phase One will connect Al Raha Beach to Yas Island, covering the airport, Etihad Plaza, Yas Mall, and SeaWorld. Construction begins next year, with service expected by 2030.

capital’s innovation in sustainable transport. In parallel, Abu Dhabi Transport also launched the Light Rail project, a key step toward building a modern mobility network.

The Light Rail aims to reduce congestion, cut emissions, and provide a fast, reliable alternative to private cars, while enhancing connectivity between residential areas, business hubs, and tourist destinations.

Government shutdown hits millions in US

THOUSANDS OF WORKERS FACE UNPAID LEAVE AS KEY SERVICES AFFECTED

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

Millions of Americans were hit yesterday as vital services shut down and government functions ground to a halt, after a bitter standoff between President Donald J. Trump and Democrats in Congress over spending triggered the first federal shutdown in nearly seven years.

Assistance for veterans transitioning to civilian life is frozen. The Centres for Disease Control and Prevention has halted health advisories. The Labour Department’s jobs report, due Friday, may not be released. Civil litigation at the Justice Department is paused. No new education grants will go out. Cleanup at toxic Superfund sites has stopped.

No salaries

Roughly 750,000 federal employees face furloughs each day, many uncertain if they will work without pay. Essential staff, from soldiers to air traffic controllers, must remain on duty but without salaries.

The political blame game began immediately. Republicans branded it “the Democrats’ shutdown,” accusing them of blocking a stopgap measure. Democrats, unusually united, countered that Trump’s refusal to compromise on expiring

VISA SERVICES

The US Bureau of Consular Affairs yesterday announced that “consular operations domestically and abroad will remain operational”.

The announcement about the consular operations includes “passports, visas and assisting American citizens abroad.” However, it added that certain domestic support for consular operations will be suspended.

health subsidies and his broader push to dismantle federal agencies had forced the closure.

Markets reacted quickly. Wall Street slipped in early trading while gold soared to a record high, reflecting investor unease. Analysts warned that a prolonged shutdown could ripple through the economy, delaying contracts, stalling benefits and undermining confidence.

This marks the third shutdown of Trump’s presidency, but the first of his second term. For Democrats, it is a line in the sand after months of frustration with the president’s agenda. For Americans reliant on federal services, it is another period of disruption and uncertainty.

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